

I wanted to block out a difficult day or looming deadline, I would start to scroll social media or browse one of my favourite shopping sites. Sometimes, when we need to stop thinking for a moment, it is these old, entrenched habits that we return to, over and over – and the more time we spend scrolling, the more susceptible we are to comparison and temptation. The more ‘stuff’ we expose ourselves to, the more we look around our own lives and possessions and find them wanting. The more we allow our online environment to warp our perception of what we have, the less able we are to feel grateful, and the less worthy we feel.

Conversely, maybe you spend not to quieten a brain that is throwing too many thoughts your way but to feel anything at all. When we are exhausted, numb or feeling low, that burst of dopamine can give us a bit of a high without us even really considering whether we want the thing we’re buying or not, a bit like the sugar rush from inhaling a pack of biscuits without really tasting them. The crash in mood (or blood sugar levels) is then more or less inevitable, and is often accompanied by frustration that the thing we did to make ourselves feel better didn’t actually even work.

Exercise: Analyse past purchases

If you can start to pick apart those catalysts for any spending that isn’t serving your financial wellbeing, or is getting in the way of your goals, you will have made the first step